Your Google Business Profile, ***step by step***

Your Google Business Profile is the box people see on Google Maps and beside your search results. It's free, and it's often the first thing a customer sees before they call. Here's how to set it up or improve it yourself, and keep it working in about 15 minutes a month.

1 Before you start

Gather these first and setup takes about 30 minutes.

- [ ] A Google account you'll keep, ideally your business email
- [ ] Your address, or the towns you serve
- [ ] A list of your main services or products
- [ ] At least 5 real photos: logo, cover, your work, team, and space
- [ ] Your business name exactly as it appears on your sign
- [ ] Phone number, website, and regular hours
- [ ] A short description of what you do (up to about 750 characters)

2 Set up or claim your profile

1. Search your business name on Google Maps. If a listing already exists, choose "Own this business?" to claim it instead of making a new one.
2. Go to google.com/business and sign in with the Google account you'll keep.
3. Enter your business name and pick the category that best fits what you do from Google's list.
4. Add your address if customers visit you. If you go to them, hide your address and list the towns you serve.
5. Add your phone number and website, then verify your business. Google may ask for a short video, a call or text, an email, or a postcard. It can take a few days.
6. Once verified, add your hours, services, description, and photos.

If someone else already owns your profile, Google lets you request access. Watch your email for its reply.

3 Improve your profile

Already have a profile? Go through this list once.

- [ ] **Name:** your real business name only. Adding towns or services can get your profile suspended.
- [ ] **Main category:** the one that matches what most customers hire you for, plus a few more for your other main services.
- [ ] **Description:** what you do, who you help, and where, in plain words. No links or phone numbers.
- [ ] **Services or products:** each one with a short line, and a price if you share prices.
- [ ] **Hours:** regular hours, plus special hours for holidays.
- [ ] **Attributes:** things like wheelchair accessible, women-owned, or online appointments, where true.
- [ ] **Links:** your website link works on phones, and your booking or quote link if you have one.
- [ ] **Photos:** real, recent, and well lit. Replace anything blurry or out of date.
- [ ] **Matching details:** name, address, and phone match your website, Facebook, Yelp, and other listings.

4 Your 15-minute monthly routine

Once a month is enough for most small businesses. Search your business name on Google while signed in to edit your profile from the results.

- [ ] Reply to new reviews
- [ ] Check your hours, phone, and website link
- [ ] Approve or reject suggested edits
- [ ] Add 2 or 3 new photos
- [ ] Add holiday hours ahead of time
- [ ] Answer new questions

5 Reviews and what to watch out for

Reviews. Ask happy customers in person and send them your review link. Ask everyone the same way, and never offer rewards for reviews. Reply to every review in a sentence or two: thank them by name, and for unhappy ones, apologize and invite them to call.

- **Scam calls:** Google doesn't call to warn that your listing will be removed or to sell "first place". Hang up.
- **Suggested edits:** anyone can suggest changes, and Google sometimes applies them. Check monthly.
- **Duplicates:** if you spot a second listing, ask Google to remove it rather than making another.
- **Access:** add helpers as managers and remove them when they're done. Never share your password.

Rather have me do it?

I'm Alexandria Cuellar, and I run Auva Studio, a digital technology and solutions studio in the Hudson Valley.

- **Google Business Profile Setup, $500:** I create or claim your profile, set up your details, categories, services, hours, and photos, and help you through verification.
- **Google Business Profile Optimization, $500:** I review the profile you have and fix what's holding it back.

Both are one-time, with no monthly plan, and you keep ownership. If you start a website with me within 6 months, $150 is credited toward it.

Take the free check at auvastudio.com/google-profile-check, or email hello@auvastudio.com

Google's screens change from time to time, so a button may have a slightly different name than the one here.